

Damara Cohn

DELRAY BEACH · BOCA RATON · THE COASTAL CORRIDOR

The Listing Playbook

A straight, practical guide to preparing, pricing, and closing the sale of your home on this coast — what actually moves the needle, what Florida law requires you to disclose, and the six things to do before your home ever hits the market.

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A NOTE FROM DAMARA



Before you list anything —

I've listed and sold homes on this stretch of coast for more than 25 years — Delray Beach, Boca Raton, and every town in between. I've watched what actually gets a home under contract at the right price, and it's rarely what sellers expect. It's almost never the biggest renovation. It's usually the smaller, unglamorous things done in the right order, at the right time.

This guide is the version of "what actually matters before you list" I'd walk you through in person, not a generic checklist pulled from a national franchise site. It covers what genuinely moves a sale here: what to fix first, what Florida law requires you to tell a buyer, what closing actually costs a seller, and the six things I ask every seller to do before we put a sign in the yard.

A few of the figures in here — staging statistics, closing cost percentages, disclosure law — come from real, current sources (cited on the page). They're a real starting point, not a valuation of your specific property. I'll always walk your actual numbers with you directly before you make any decision.

One more thing, since it matters to how I work: I run a boutique brokerage, not a large national franchise. That means the person you talk to on day one is the same person overseeing your sale through closing — my personal attention, my 25+ years of local expertise, not a rotating cast of assistants. If something in here raises a question, just ask me directly.

Damara

BROKER-OWNER, MANGROVE REALTY

WHAT ACTUALLY MOVES A SALE

Prep Matters More Than Renovation

Every seller asks whether a big renovation is worth it before listing. Usually, no. What consistently moves the needle is smaller and more specific — and the numbers back it up.

83%

of buyers' agents say
staging helps buyers
picture themselves living in
a home

49%

of sellers' agents say
staged homes spend less
time on market than
unstaged ones

1-10%+

typical offer increase
reported by sellers' agents
on staged listings

Source: National Association of Realtors, Profile of Home Staging. On a median-priced home, that offer range translates to roughly \$4,000–\$40,000—plus in additional offers — real money for an average staging spend of well under \$2,000.

The Four I Ask Every Seller to Check First

Before we talk paint colors or furniture, I want to know the condition of the four systems that kill more deals at inspection than anything cosmetic ever will. Buyers' inspectors go straight to these — so should you, before a buyer ever walks through.

1

Roof

2

Plumbing

3

Electric

4

A/C

A roof with real remaining life, updated plumbing and electric, and a working, serviced A/C system will do more for your sale price and your negotiating position than a kitchen remodel — and cost a fraction as much to address if something needs attention. I walk every listing through these four before we set a price.

The Seller Questions Everyone Actually Asks

"What am I legally required to tell a buyer?"

Florida follows a rule from a case called *Johnson v. Davis*: sellers must disclose facts that materially affect the property's value when those facts aren't easily observable and the buyer doesn't already know them. In plain terms — if something is wrong with the property that a normal walkthrough wouldn't reveal (water intrusion behind a wall, a hidden structural issue, a drainage problem, a roof issue papered over), you're required to say so. This isn't optional, and getting it wrong can mean real legal exposure after closing, not just a renegotiation before it. When in doubt, disclose it — I'll help you word it correctly.

"What will closing actually cost me as the seller?"

In Florida, sellers typically pay the documentary stamp tax on the deed (\$0.70 per \$100 of sale price), the real estate commission (averaging around 5.5% total, split between listing and buyer's agents), and a share of title-related fees. All-in, most Florida sellers pay somewhere between 8% and 9.5% of the sale price at closing when commission is included — roughly 3–3.5% excluding it. Everything here is technically negotiable in the contract, but knowing the local default before you negotiate is the whole point.

Doc stamps: \$0.70/\$100

Avg. commission: ~5.5%

Total w/ commission: 8–9.5%

"How do we actually land on the right price?"

Not by asking what the neighbor's house sold for. A real pricing strategy looks at genuinely comparable closed sales (not just listings — asking prices mean nothing), current absorption rate for your specific price tier and town, and where your home's condition sits relative to those comps after the prep work above. I build every listing's price from a real market analysis specific to your address, not a national algorithm's estimate — those are frequently off by 10% or more on this coast.

BEFORE YOU LIST

The Six-Step Pre-Listing Checklist

Run through these before your home goes on the market — whether you're selling a starter condo or an estate, the order matters.

- 1

Check the Four — roof, plumbing, electric, A/C

Address anything a buyer's inspector will flag before it becomes a negotiating point after you're already under contract. Small fixes now are cheaper than credits later.

- 2

Declutter and depersonalize before you stage anything

The research is consistent: buyers need to picture themselves living there, and a home full of your personal history makes that harder, not more charming. This step is free and matters more than furniture.

- 3

Get a real market analysis, not an algorithm's guess

Online home-value estimates are frequently off by a meaningful margin on this coast, in both directions. Price it from actual closed comps and current absorption, not a national tool's model.

- 4

Know your disclosure obligations before showings start

Walk through what Florida law requires you to disclose (see the Straight Answers page) with your agent before the first buyer walks in, not after an offer comes in.

- 5

Understand your net proceeds before you set a number

Know your realistic closing costs (commission, doc stamps, title fees, and your remaining mortgage payoff) so the number you accept is one you actually understand, not just a headline price.

- 6

Line up your next move before you accept an offer

Selling fast is a good problem to have if you're not ready to move. Have a realistic plan for closing timing, a rent-back if needed, or your next purchase, before your home is under contract.

IN THEIR WORDS

"I used Damara and Mangrove Realty for all of my real estate needs for years. I have referred her to my closest friends and 3 of them sold their home with her. They all love Damara and Mangrove! Always great service and results. They are the best real estate company in South Florida!"

— DAN K., GOOGLE REVIEW

LET'S TALK

Honest answers. Genuine care. 25+ years of experience.

I run a boutique brokerage, not a large national franchise — which means you get my direct oversight, attention, and expertise from your first call through closing, not a hand-off to someone you've never spoken to.

Selling a home you've lived in is rarely just a transaction — it's a decision with real weight behind it. Whatever question is on your mind, ask me directly. I'll give you the same honest, straightforward answer I'd give a friend.

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Mangrove Realty, Inc. · Licensed Real Estate Brokerage

Damara Cohn, Broker-Owner, Mangrove Realty · Delray Beach, FL · This guide is for general informational purposes only. Staging statistics are sourced from the National Association of Realtors' Profile of Home Staging; disclosure-law and closing-cost figures reflect general Florida norms as of 2026 and vary by property, county, and transaction. Not tax or legal advice — confirm current figures and obligations with your closing attorney or title company before making a decision.